> desired me to take my rings off from my fingers, and to conceal them somewhere, so that the avarice of his son might not tempt him to cut off my fingers with them. My house was in the meantime comprehensively plundered.[9]

Since Mohan Lal, the closest direct observer, was now secreted inside a zenana, there are no eyewitness accounts surviving of the final moments of Burnes, and the different versions that exist are all, to different extents, hearsay. The least likely version – though certainly the most imaginative – is that of Mirza ‘Ata. In his narration, when the ghazis burst into the compound,

> it is said that Burnes at that moment was in the private quarters of the house, taking a bath with his mistress in the hot water of lust and pleasure . . . At this point, the guerrilla Ghazis burst in and dragged them all from the changing room of life, cut them down with their swords and threw their corpses into the ash-pit of death. Everything in the house was plundered, the fighters breaking open the treasure chests and filling the skirts of their clothes with Company coins which clinked with a loud noise: ‘shereng, shereng!’ The fighters then attacked the house of the Bakhshi [paymaster] Captain [Hugh] Johnson and plundered the godown of all its stores and treasure; any English who found themselves in the city of Kabul tried to escape as best they could and make their way to the cantonment.[10]

A variant on this story is given by Munshi Abdul Karim in the *Muharaba Kabul wa Kandahar*. Like Mirza ‘Ata, Munshi Abdul Karim takes the view that the crisis was largely precipitated by Burnes’s allegedly gargantuan sexual appetites. In the view of the munshi, the flashpoint was not a slave girl of Abdullah Khan Achakzai, but ‘Burnes’ falling in lust with an Afghan woman and imprisoning of her husband’.

> It is said that, one day, he was walking to inspect the city and suddenly caught sight of a young Afghan woman, peerless in beauty, standing on the flat roof of her house. Burnes immediately became obsessed by the sight of her, and, forgetting his duties, or any sense of piety or shame, as soon as he returned to his office, summoned the Kotwal, the chief of police, to fetch the householder of that particular house in that particular quarter. The constable ran to carry out his orders and arrived back with a young Afghan soldier, upright and pious, the owner of that house and husband of that peerless beauty. Burnes said ‘I have work for you – if you do my bidding, I shall make you an officer, I shall make you rich, I shall make you one of my intimates!’
>
> ‘And what is that work? That I may strive to fulfil your wishes?’ asked the young soldier.
>
> ‘You have a wife, beautiful as the full moon, whom I saw standing on the roof of your house: I cannot get her out of my mind; give her to me, let me assuage my passion, and anything you ask shall be yours!’
>
> The young soldier trembled with shame, fell into a fury of outraged honour and hissed: ‘You filthy animal! Have you no fear of God? Am I a pander, to sell my wife to you for gold?